“Anything, but mostly buildings. I studied architecture at L’Ecole des Beaux-Arts for a while. Shall we introduce ourselves properly? I’m André Simon. And you are?”

“Rose Cotillard.”

“Rose Cotillard,” he repeated, bowing his head slightly. “*Enchanté*.”

She felt her cheeks flush with heat at how he said her name, soft and slow like the patter of rain. She wondered if he was the same age as Léa—twenty-two. But then he would have been drafted at the start of the war and sent to Germany. He had to be Rose’s age, or maybe a year older.

“May I look at your sketches?”

She handed him the book and watched as he turned the pages. He smiled at the chickens pecking the ground outside the coop, the large plane tree with its broad leaves in the school playground, and Léa’s portrait.

“Who’s that?” A tuft of hair fell across his forehead.

“My sister.”

“I can see she resembles you a little, at least from what you’ve drawn. What does she do?”

“She’s a typist in a notary’s office.”

He continued to turn the pages, stopping at the boat she’d drawn two weeks ago. “You have a good eye, but—”

“What?”

“Can you see what’s wrong here?”

Rose leaned forward. “Wrong?”

“Forgive me, I don’t mean to offend you—”

“Oh, I’m not offended. I sensed something’s off—the sail?”

“Yes. You see how it’s too wide in relation to the hull? The perspective is wrong.” He pointed at the river, where a similar boat was docked. “There’s a technique for checking perspective.”

She had always guessed the distance between things—the sail, mast and hull. She didn’t know how else to do it.

“I can show you if you’d like.” He lifted a pencil from his shirt pocket. “May I?”

“Yes.”

“The key is to measure the distances between objects before you draw.” He turned to an empty page. “Let’s take that boat on the river. Use a pencil by holding it with your thumb at the midpoint, like this—” Extending his